

In the 1920s, airmail pilots were an elite group flying regular services across some of the Earth's most inhospitable terrain. Mail could be carried over many long-distance routes that were simply not safe enough for passenger transportation. Subsidized by governments eager to promote aviation, airmail became a testing ground for scheduled commercial services. It allowed high-risk experiments in flying at night and in poor weather conditions, the application of new navigational techniques, and the development of support services and infrastructure, from airfields to weather forecasting. Airmail pilots were inculcated with a spirit of team discipline and professional dedication. They accepted high risks but were taught to minimize losses of aircraft or mail, while doing everything humanly possible to keep to a strict schedule.

Aéropostale

One of the first scheduled airmail services maintained under hazardous conditions was the organization for which Jean Mermoz and his colleagues flew, first known simply as *La Ligne* ("The Line") and later as Aéropostale. Founded by businessman Pierre-Georges Latécoère and based in Toulouse in southwest France, *La Ligne* began airmail flights in 1919, through Spain to Casablanca in Morocco. The extension of the postal service to Dakar on the coast of French West Africa followed in 1925. Two years later, Aéropostale boldly moved into South America, where the field had been left open for European competition. From March 1928, an airmail service of sorts linked France to Rio de Janeiro in Brazil – the mail crossed the Atlantic by boat from Dakar to the Brazilian port of Natal, from where it was flown on to Rio. In the 1930s, French pilots established regular flights across the South Atlantic in flying boats, as well as a network of airmail routes in Brazil, Argentina, and Chile.



POST OFFICE

The Aéropostale airmail company – one of the offices of which is shown above – was based in Toulouse, southwest France, and was the first to establish a regular mail service between South America and Europe.



JEAN MERMOZ

JEAN MERMOZ (1901–36)

flew for the French army in Syria before joining the Latécoère line as an airmail pilot in 1924. After an adventurous period flying mail across North Africa, he was given the job of trail-blazing Aéropostale routes in South America in 1927. In 1928 Mermoz made the first night flight from Buenos Aires, Argentina, to Rio

FRENCH LEGEND

During the 1930s Mermoz became involved in French politics, exploiting his heroic status to drum up support for La Croix du Feu, an extreme right-wing organization.

WINGED HEAD

This stamp, bearing the portrait of French trail-blazer Jean Mermoz, was created to commemorate his feats of daring and bravery.



de Janeiro, Brazil. The following year, he embarked on the hazardous exploration of routes across the Andes to Chile. On one occasion, while making a forced landing on an Andean mountainside, he leapt from the aircraft and stopped the machine from rolling into a ravine by sheer muscle power. Such exploits – which lost nothing in the telling – along with a series of bold flights across the South Atlantic, made Mermoz a French national hero. On December 7, 1936, Mermoz crashed while piloting his flying boat, *La Croix du Sud*, across the South Atlantic. No trace of the crew or aircraft was ever found.

The exploits of the airmail pilots – not only Mermoz, but others such as Henri Guillaumet and the pilot-author Antoine de Saint-Exupéry – became legends of French aviation. The stories of some of their more extreme adventures, although well attested, read like fiction. In March 1929, for example, looking for a new route across the Andes from Chile to Argentina, Mermoz and his mechanic Alexandre Collenot crashed at around 13,000ft (4,000m) on a rocky slope surrounded by steep crevasses. For four days they worked in subzero temperatures to repair their Latécoère LAT 26, using what they had on hand – scraps of rubber, leather, fabric, wire, and glue. They then had to take off down a stony slope that was

fissured by two crevasses, which they hopped over as they gathered enough speed to lift off. The engine soon failed, but fortunately, once they had cleared the peaks, they were able to glide safely back down to the Chilean plains.

Army airmail

In the United States, airmail blazed the trail for commercial aviation from coast to coast, after a decidedly uncertain start. On May 15, 1918, with World War I still in progress, the Army Air Service was informed that it would be initiating the world's first regular airmail service, between Washington, D.C., and New York, via Philadelphia, until such time as the Post Office could procure its own pilots and aircraft. It was a task for which Army pilots and their Curtiss Jennys were ill-prepared. The first mail to leave Washington had a high-profile sendoff, with President Wilson himself in attendance, but the inexperienced pilot, Lt. George L. Boyle, got lost immediately

NEW ROUTES

The French government hoped to use Aéropostale to help it conquer the commercial aviation market. Mermoz pioneered night flights over long distances to give airmail a clear advantage over ground mail.

